

FAA Aircraft Preventive Maintenance: Scope and Limits

Quick reference | 14 CFR Part 43, § 43.3 and Appendix A(c)

What “preventive maintenance” means here

Part 43 Appendix A(c) lists specific preventive-maintenance tasks and limits the category to listed work that does not involve complex assembly operations. The list is regulatory and task-specific; a task that sounds simple is not automatically preventive maintenance.

Who may perform it?

Section 43.3(g) allows a qualifying Part 61 pilot to perform preventive maintenance on an aircraft owned or operated by that pilot, subject to the regulation and its exclusions. It does not authorize every pilot to perform every maintenance task. Aircraft use, certificate status, task scope, and other exceptions matter.

Examples from Appendix A(c)

Listed examples include removing, installing, or repairing landing-gear tires; servicing shock struts with oil or air; servicing wheel bearings; replacing safety wire or cotter keys; lubrication that does not require disassembly beyond removing nonstructural covers; replenishing hydraulic fluid; replacing safety belts; and replacing specified light bulbs. These examples do not override aircraft-specific instructions or other applicable rules.

Record and approval

A person who performs qualifying preventive maintenance must make the applicable record entry under § 43.9. Section 43.7(f) provides a limited return-to-service approval path for a pilot after that pilot performs authorized preventive maintenance on an aircraft owned or operated by that pilot. This is not general authority to approve unrelated maintenance.

Before relying on this summary

Check the complete current Appendix A(c) item, §§ 43.3, 43.7 and 43.9, the aircraft maintenance manual or Instructions for Continued Airworthiness, and applicable operating limitations. Stop and use appropriately authorized maintenance personnel when the task is not clearly within the listed scope or requires complex assembly.

OFFICIAL SOURCES

eCFR, 14 CFR Part 43, § 43.3, § 43.7, § 43.9 and Appendix A(c): <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-14/chapter-I/subchapter-C/part-43>

Educational summary only; not maintenance instructions, approved technical data, or authorization to perform or approve work. Verify current regulations, aircraft-specific instructions, airworthiness directives, and individual certificate privileges. This summary is not a substitute for the current eCFR.